TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

Fashion Figure Drawing

The croquis: building the fashion figure on the eight-head canon, placing every landmark by proportion, and dressing the figure so the garment — not the anatomy — stays the subject.

AM-4203 · FASHION DESIGN AND PRODUCT ENGINEERING · TOPIC 2 · LEVEL 4 TERM 2

1. What the fashion figure is for

The fashion figure (**croquis**, from the French for a rough sketch) is the designer's working mannequin on paper. Its job is communication: to show how a garment will look on a body — its silhouette, proportions, details and movement — clearly enough that a pattern maker, a buyer or a client can judge the design before cloth is cut. It is deliberately not an anatomy drawing: the fashion figure is elongated and simplified so that the *garment* reads first.

2. The eight-head canon

Figure proportion is measured in **head units** — the length of the head from crown to chin. A naturalistic standing figure measures about 7½ heads; fashion drawing standardises on **8 heads**, and high-fashion illustration often stretches to 9. The landmarks fall at fixed head counts, which is what makes the system drawable at any scale:

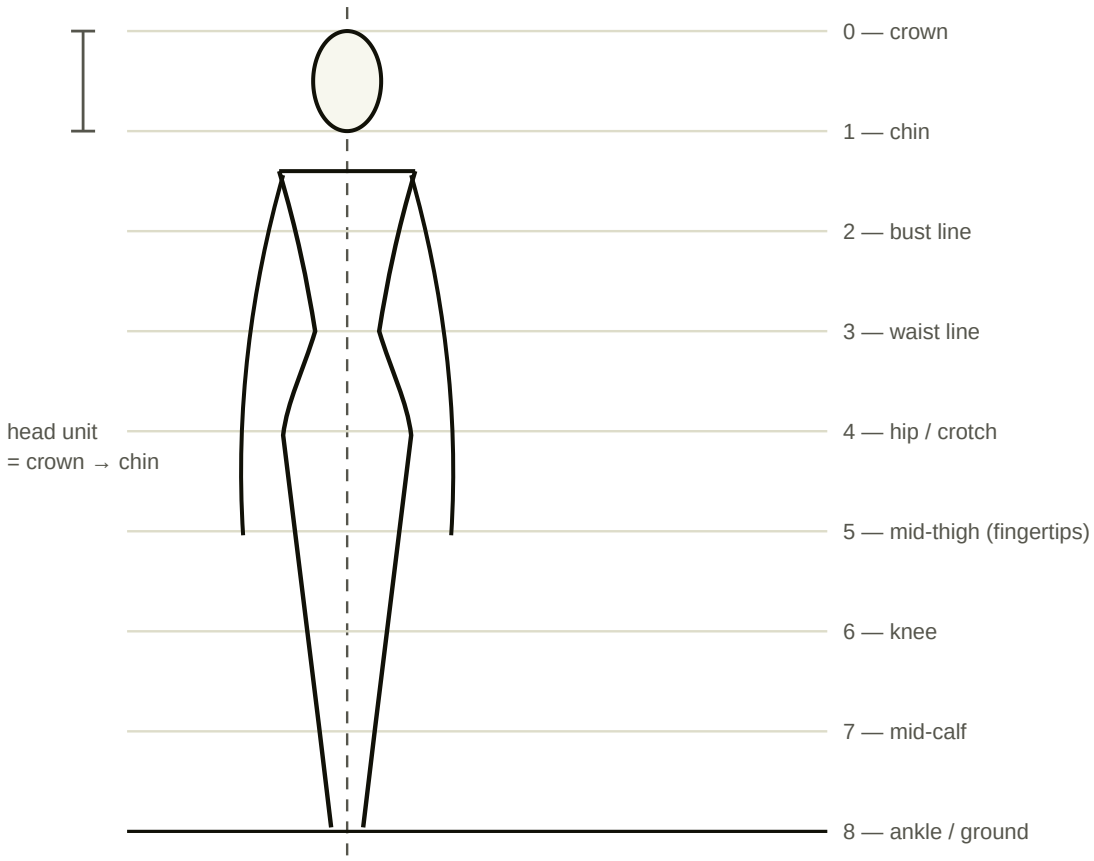


Figure 1 — The eight-head croquis. Every horizontal line is one head unit below the last; widths are set against the same unit — on this figure the shoulder line spans about 1⅓ units, the waist narrows to roughly ⅔ of a unit, and the hips widen again toward the 4-head line.

HEADS	LANDMARK	DRAWING USE
0–1	Crown to chin	The head itself; face features sit in its lower two-thirds.
2	Bust line	Dart points, empire lines and yokes are keyed to this level.
3	Waist line; elbows	The balance line of the design; belts, waist seams, jacket breaks.
4	Hip line and crotch; wrists	Fullest hip level; skirt and trouser construction hangs from here.
5	Mid-thigh; fingertips	The natural end of a hanging arm — the fastest correctness check in any figure.
6	Knee	Hemline reference ("knee-length" means ending at this line).
7	Mid-calf	Midi lengths and boot tops key to this level.

8	Ankle and ground	Feet and the ground line that keeps the figure standing, not floating.

3. Building the figure: the working method

1. **Set the scale.** Decide the figure's total height on the page and divide it into eight equal units; rule the nine division lines lightly across the page.
2. **Draw the balance line.** A vertical through the figure's centre: in a standing pose it falls from the pit of the neck through the supporting foot. Weight-bearing poses tilt the pelvis and shoulders in opposite directions (contrapposto) around this line — the source of natural movement in a figure.
3. **Block the masses.** Head as an oval; shoulders, bust, waist and hip as horizontal bars of the widths in Figure 1, placed on their division lines; join them with the body's contour.
4. **Add the limbs.** Arms as two-segment lines (shoulder–elbow at the waist line, elbow–wrist at the hip line, fingertips at mid-thigh); legs from the hip line through knee to ankle. Check both arms against the landmarks — wrong arm length is the commonest beginner's fault.
5. **Dress the figure.** Draw the garment *around* the body, not on it: the cloth stands off the body by its ease and stiffness, follows the body's movement at its contact points (shoulder, waist, hip), and falls in folds from them. Neckline, sleeves, hem and details are placed against the division lines so their positions can be read and reproduced.
6. **Finish.** Strengthen the garment's outline, indicate fabric behaviour with a few fold lines, add face and hair last and lightly — detail in the face steals attention from the design.

4. Poses and templates

Working designers rarely draw the figure from zero for every design. A personal set of **template croquis** — front, three-quarter and back poses, walking and seated — is traced or used as an underlay, and the design is drawn over it; fashion CAD systems supply the same templates digitally. The template guarantees proportion and speed; the design drawn over it supplies the originality. Back views are not optional: a design is not finished until its back is drawn, because garments are seen from behind as often as from the front.

> **WORKED PROPORTION EXAMPLE**
>
> A croquis is to be drawn 36 cm tall on the sheet. Head unit = 36 ÷ 8 = **4.5 cm**. The waist line falls at 3 units = 3 × 4.5 = **13.5 cm below the crown**; the knee at 6 units = 27.0 cm; fingertips must end at 5 units = 22.5 cm. Every landmark in the drawing is placed by this single division — no part of the figure is measured against any other part.

Glossary

TERM	MEANING
Croquis	The fashion figure drawing used as the base for presenting designs; also the quick sketch itself.
Head unit	Head length (crown to chin), the module from which the figure's proportions are built.
Balance line	The vertical through the body's centre of support; poses are organised around it.
Contrapposto	The natural standing pose with pelvis and shoulders tilted in opposition, weight on one leg.
Template figure	A pre-drawn standard croquis traced or used digitally as the base for many designs.

Key points and summary

- The fashion figure is built in head units: 8 heads standard, landmarks at fixed counts (bust 2, waist 3, hip 4, fingertips 5, knee 6, ankle 8).
- Method: scale and divisions → balance line → blocked masses → limbs checked against landmarks → garment drawn around the body → finish lightly.
- Templates and digital croquis give speed and consistency; every design still needs front and back views.
- Correct proportion is what lets a drawing be read as a specification, not just an impression.

Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. A figure is drawn 30 cm tall on the 8-head canon. Give the head unit and the distances from the crown to the waist and to the fingertips.
2. A student's figure looks wrong: the hands end at the knee line. What proportion error has been made?
3. Why is the garment drawn around the body rather than exactly on the body's contour?
4. State the drawing order in §3 and the purpose of the balance line.

Answer key

1. Head unit = 30 ÷ 8 = 3.75 cm. Waist at 3 units = 11.25 cm; fingertips at 5 units = 18.75 cm below the crown.
2. The arms are too long (or the legs too short): fingertips belong at mid-thigh, 5 heads; ending at the knee (6 heads) means a full head unit of excess arm — checked instantly against the division lines.
3. Because cloth does not coincide with the body: ease, fabric stiffness and gravity hold it away from the surface except at support points. Drawing on the contour makes garments look sprayed on and misstates every silhouette.
4. Scale/divisions, balance line, blocked masses, limbs, garment, finish. The balance line fixes where the weight is carried, so the pose stands naturally and the garment hangs from the correct points.

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